Choosing an English Bible Translation

A plain guide to the word-for-word, thought-for-thought and paraphrase spectrum — which version suits which reader, which to study from, and which to leave on the shelf.

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Start here

WHAT THIS GUIDE DOES AND DOES NOT CLAIM

Every English Bible sits somewhere between two goals: keeping the original words, and being understood. No version achieves both perfectly. This guide shows where each one sits and what that costs you.

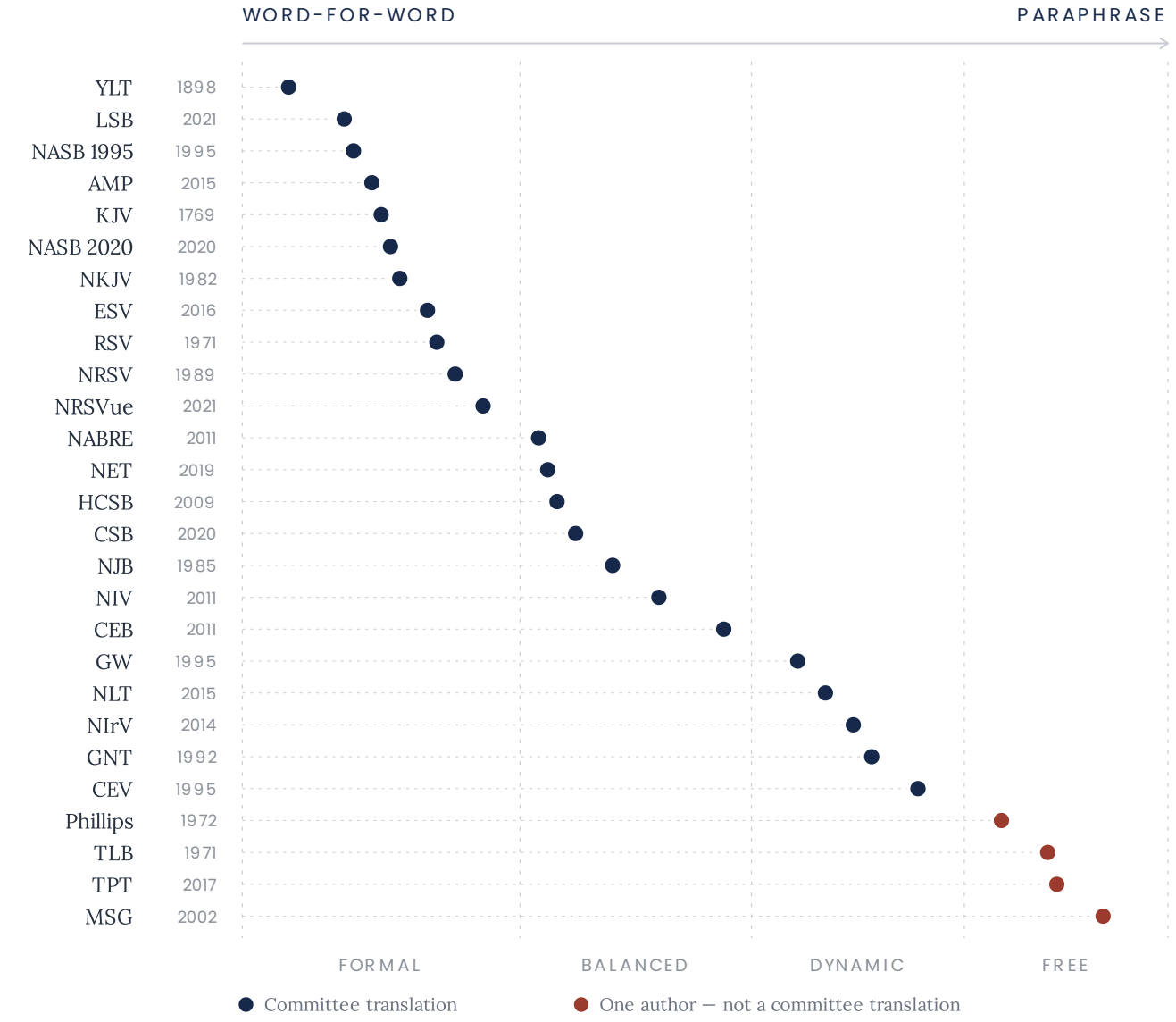
Two honest warnings before the chart. First, the positions below reflect stated translation philosophy and scholarly assessment. There is no published measurement of how literal a Bible is, and every publisher's own chart puts its own product in the sweet spot.

Second, the line is softer than it looks. Dave Brunn, who translated the whole New Testament into Lamogai in Papua New Guinea, compared hundreds of passages and found that versions marketed as literal frequently are not. The Hebrew word *barak* means "bless", yet in four places in Job the ESV renders it "curse" — the exact opposite — as does every other version. His conclusion was that no translation applies its own philosophy consistently.

> **The one thing to take away.** The best translation is a good committee translation you will actually open. Most arguments about which one are smaller than the gap between reading and not reading.

The spectrum

TWENTY-SEVEN ENGLISH VERSIONS



Position reflects stated philosophy and scholarly assessment, not measured data. Year shown is the current edition.

Reading the four zones. Formal versions follow the original word order and vocabulary as closely as English allows — best for study, hardest to read. **Balanced** versions translate literally where that is clear and rephrase where it is not — the usual choice for a main Bible. **Dynamic** versions translate meaning rather than words, so the sense arrives quickly but the original wording is gone. **Free** versions restate the text in the author's own words; three of the four here are the work of one man.

How well each keeps the balance

ACCURACY AGAINST READABILITY

Reading ages are converted from published US grade levels and are approximate — sources disagree by up to two years. They also measure sentence and word length only. “Propitiation” counts as an easy word, so a low reading age does not mean the theology is simple.

VERSION	LITERAL → FREE	READING AGE	BALANCE	COMMENT
YLT 1898		17+	Broken	Literalness so extreme the English stops working.
LSB 2021		15	Skewed literal	NASB 1995 made more consistent. Uses “Yahweh” throughout the Old Testament.
NASB 1995 1995		16	Skewed literal	Precision bought at a real cost in readability.
AMP 2015		16	Poor	Bracketed expansions slip commentary into the text.
KJV 1769		17	Unfair to score	Literal method, but 400-year-old English is the real barrier.
NASB 2020 2020		15	Improved	Smoother than 1995; slightly less consistent.
NKJV 1982		13–14	Good	Best readability gain for the literalness given up.
ESV 2016		15	Solid	“Essentially literal”. Some stiff older syntax remains.
RSV 1971		15	Solid but dated	Now largely replaced by the ESV and NRSVue.
NRSV 1989		15–16	Good	Long-standing academic standard.
NRSVue 2021		15	Good	The most up-to-date formal option on the manuscript evidence.
NABRE 2011		12–13	Strong	Underrated outside Catholic use.
NET 2019		13	Excellent	60,000+ notes show every translation decision.
HCSB 2009		12–13	Strong	Idiosyncratic in places; replaced by the CSB.
CSB 2020		12	Excellent	Close to the best trade-off available.
NJB 1985		14–15	Fair	Literary quality prioritised over consistency.
NIV 2011		12–13	Excellent	Often more literal than its reputation suggests.
CEB 2011		12	Fair	Readability bought with real interpretive licence.
GW 1995		10	Fair	Good for its brief. Not a study text.
NLT 2015		11	Good for its brief	Very clear, but the decisions are made for you.
NIrV 2014		8	Good for its brief	Built for early readers and English learners.

VERSION	LITERAL → FREE	READING AGE	BALANCE	COMMENT
GNT 1992		11–12	Fair	Deliberately restricted vocabulary.
CEV 1995		10–11	Fair	Heavily restructured sentences.
Phillips 1972		13	Not applicable	One author, New Testament only, openly free.
TLB 1971		12–13	Poor	A paraphrase of an English Bible, not of Hebrew or Greek.
TPT 2017		11–12	Poor	One author. Widely criticised for adding material.
MSG 2002		9–10	Not applicable	Companion reading. Never a base text.

Which one suits which reader

MATCH THE VERSION TO THE PERSON

You struggle to focus, or lose the thread mid-chapter

CSB

Short sentences and a plain word order, without giving up much accuracy. If focus is the issue, also look at the Clear Focus Bible — Zondervan's edition using the Bionic Reading layout, which bolds the front of each word and widens the line spacing. It comes in NIV, NASB 1995 and NIrV.

You have dyslexia or find dense print hard

GNT or NIrV

Here the page matters more than the translation. The Bible Society sells a dyslexia-friendly edition of Genesis using the GNB, laid out to British Dyslexia Association principles. Large print and single-column settings help more than switching version.

You are new to the faith and want to understand it first time

NLT, then NIV

The NLT removes almost all the friction. Move to the NIV or CSB once you are reading comfortably — you will want something you can study from.

You want one Bible for the rest of your life

CSB or NIV

Both are accurate enough to preach from and clear enough to read for an hour without tiring. This is the safest single choice.

You want to study properly — word studies, cross-references, Greek and Hebrew

NASB 1995 or LSB, alongside the NET

The NASB and LSB keep the original wording visible. The NET tells you where the decisions were made, which is the part most Bibles hide.

You preach or teach

CSB or ESV

Both read aloud well and hold up when you press on the wording. Keep a NIV or NLT beside you to check how a passage will land.

You are memorising Scripture

ESV or NKJV

Rhythm helps memory. Both have a deliberate cadence the more casual versions lack.

You grew up on the King James and want to keep the feel

NKJV

Same underlying Greek text, same cadence, modern spelling and grammar.

You are studying theology formally

NRSVue

The expected version in most universities and seminaries, and text-critically the most current.

English is not your first language

NIrV or GNT

Both use a controlled vocabulary. The NIrV is based on the NIV, so moving up later is easy.

You are reading with children

NIrV or NLT

The NIrV is written at about an eight-year-old's reading age; the NLT suits older children reading independently.

You are Catholic

NABRE or NRSVue

Both include the deuterocanonical books. The NJB is also widely used and reads well, though it is looser.

Best for each purpose

QUICK REFERENCE

PURPOSE	USE	WHY
Serious study	NET → NASB1995 / LSB → ESV	The NET first, because its notes show the working.
Daily reading	CSB or NIV	Accurate enough to trust, easy enough to keep going.
First Bible	NLT	Understanding comes first. Precision can come later.
Preaching and teaching	CSB, ESV, NKJV	Clear when read aloud, defensible when examined.
Memorising	ESV, NKJV	Cadence makes verses stick.
Academic work	NRSVue, NET	What examiners and journals expect.
Low reading confidence	NIrV, GNT	Plain vocabulary, short sentences.
Devotional variety	NLT, or MSG strictly alongside a real translation	Useful for a fresh angle. Never the text you build on.

> **A practical habit.** Read from one good translation. When a verse is unclear, check it in one more literal version and one more readable one. Where all three agree, the meaning is settled. Where they differ, you have found a genuine question worth looking into.

The problem with paraphrases

WHY THEY SHOULD NOT BE YOUR MAIN BIBLE

A paraphrase is not a bad thing. It is a different thing. It is one person telling you what they think a passage means, written in the shape of a Bible. Read as commentary, that can be refreshing. Read as Scripture, it

quietly replaces the text with an opinion.

1. **You get a conclusion, not the text.** Where the original is genuinely ambiguous, a paraphrase picks one meaning and gives no sign that a choice was made. A translation leaves the ambiguity visible so you can weigh it.
2. **You cannot study from it.** Word studies, cross-references and repeated key terms all depend on the same original word being rendered consistently. Paraphrases vary the wording for freshness, which breaks every one of those tools.
3. **It cannot settle a disagreement.** If two Christians read a passage differently, a paraphrase cannot adjudicate — it is already one of the interpretations on the table.
4. **The structure disappears.** Hebrew poetry works by parallel lines; Greek argument works by long connected clauses. Smoothing these into modern prose removes the very features the author used to make the point.
5. **It grows.** Free renderings add explanatory words. Once added, a reader cannot tell them apart from the text. Over a whole Bible this amounts to thousands of words no biblical author wrote.
6. **There is usually no check.** Committee translations contain dozens of scholars from different churches who have to agree. A single author answers to nobody, so their blind spots go straight onto the page.

> **The honest test.** Ask of any version: if I built a doctrine on this sentence, could I defend it from the Hebrew or Greek? For a committee translation the answer is yes, even where you might have rendered it differently. For a paraphrase it is no — you would be defending the paraphraser.

So treat a paraphrase the way you would treat a good Christian book: read it, enjoy it, let it show you a familiar passage from a new angle. Then go back to your Bible for anything you intend to believe, teach or build your life on. The difference matters most precisely when a passage is hard, which is exactly when the paraphrase is most tempting.

One author, or heavily altered

VERSIONS TO BE CAREFUL WITH

The Message (MSG)

Eugene Peterson, alone

Peterson worked from Hebrew and Greek and was always open that this is a paraphrase, not a translation. He never claimed otherwise. The problem is how people use it, not how he described it.

The Living Bible (TLB)

Kenneth Taylor, alone

Not translated from Hebrew or Greek at all. Taylor reworded the 1901 American Standard Version into simpler English — a paraphrase of an English Bible. Every distance from the original is doubled.

J.B. Phillips New Testament

J.B. Phillips, alone

New Testament only, and openly free. Written to be readable rather than exact, and honest about it. Fine as supplementary reading.

The Passion Translation (TPT)

Brian Simmons, lead translator; no published team

The serious case. Themelios described it as abandoning textual accuracy and inserting so much new material that the text runs at least 50% longer than the original. Bible Gateway removed it in 2022; YouVersion placed it under review. It is marketed as a translation, which is the part that does the damage.

Amplified Bible (AMP)

Committee, but built on one editor's expansions

Not a paraphrase, but the bracketed alternatives are interpretation printed as if it were text. A reader cannot tell what is in the Greek and what is the editor's gloss.

> **A different failure, same lesson.** The New World Translation is formally quite literal, yet renders passages such as Colossians 1:15–18 in line with Watchtower doctrine. Literalness is no guarantee of honesty. What protects a reader is an open, named, mixed committee whose work can be checked — not a position on the chart.

If you only remember one page

Read the CSB or NIV daily. Study with the NET beside it. Keep the NASB 1995 or LSB for close work on wording, and the NLT for when you are tired or reading aloud to someone new.

Treat The Message, The Living Bible and Phillips as Christian books — useful, but not the text. Leave The Passion Translation alone entirely; it presents itself as a translation and is not one.

Sources

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Dave Brunn, *One Bible, Many Versions* (IVP Academic, 2013) — on the inconsistency of "literal" translations. · Andrew Shead, review of The Passion Translation Psalms, *Themelios* (The Gospel Coalition). · Review of the Christian Standard Bible, *Themelios* — on "optimal equivalence" as a marketing term. · *Christianity Today*, "How The Passion Translation's Problems Hid in Plain Sight" (August 2026). · Christianbook.com, Bible translation reading levels chart. · CSB, ESV, NASB, LSB, NET, NIV and NRSVue publisher prefaces and translation-philosophy statements. · Friendship Press / SBL on the NRSV Updated Edition. · Zondervan / Bionic Reading, Clear Focus Bible. · Bible Society UK, dyslexia-friendly editions.